neither was India involved in such activities. Yet, 'turn[ing] over' Brahamdagh to Pakistan, Karzai underlined, would create tremendous 'disgust' among Afghans for Washington and Karzai.[138] While Boucher's shuttle diplomacy yielded no visible results, in September 2008 the Pakistan army and the Baloch separatists declared a ceasefire. If there ever was an India-Afghanistan axis on Balochistan, it was likely to be in full play during this time. That the NDS chief Saleh was closely engaged with the Baloch rebels as well as Narayanan was amply clear. Even if Indian intelligence agencies did not directly support the Baloch insurgents, it is unlikely that they remained aloof from the unfolding dynamic.

Khare, who followed these events on a regular and intimate basis, confirms that India had contacts with the Baloch separatists.[139] India had given (limited) protection to the sons and grandsons of most Baloch leaders, and Akbar Bugti was well known in variety of Indian circles. But still, India did not support the insurrection when the Pakistan army launched heavy counter-attacks. 'We allowed them to do that [kill Bugti] ... and didn't say much', Khare argues.[140] Despite the partisans' willingness to build pressure on Pakistan, Manmohan Singh was keen on preserving the peace process with Islamabad. Musharraf was a promising bet on that count. As Singh told the US in October 2008, 'we want our activities in Afghanistan to be an open book'.[141] No evidence emerged of India's direct, or indirect (via Afghanistan) support to the insurgency. But in January 2009, the insurgency was reignited after the three Baloch groups called-off the ceasefire. Brahmdagh threatened retaliation if Islamabad did not stop army operations in Balochistan, release political prisoners, account for alleged missing persons, and give autonomy to the province.[142] The breakdown of the ceasefire just two months after the 26/11 Mumbai attacks convinced Pakistan that Brahmdagh had India's support. Not just Pakistan, but even the UK was convinced that supporting proxies in Balochistan would be the 'minimum' India would do in response, and targeting LeT training camps in Pakistan-administered Kashmir was the 'maximum' (the US did not share British concerns).[143]

On 27 April 2009, Pakistan's interior minister Rehman Malik openly blamed India, Afghanistan, and Russia for supporting the BLA. A sharp increase in the number of rocket attacks and bombings against Pakistan's Frontier Corps pushed Islamabad to blame Indian consulates in Afghanistan for trying to dismember